



SUNIL TATKARE

PORTFOLIO Energy

SCORE CARD Several power projects are stuck due to the government's

lackadaisical approach. Transmission and distribution losses are at a high of about 39.4 per cent while the Centre stipulation is 16 per cent.

WORK IN PROGRESS All the mega power projects are stuck as the Government is unable to acquire land from farmers.



RAJENDRA SHINGNE

PORTFOLIO: Family Welfare, Health

SCORE CARD The CBI recently

unearthed a Rs 100-crore scam in which anti-cancer medicines were being smuggled out of the dispensary of the Tata Memorial Hospital. The state ranks high in child mortality rate with 1,60,000 deaths a year.

WORK IN PROGRESS The State needs to do a lot more to set up health centres in rural areas.



VIJAYSINH MOHITE-PATIL

PORTFOLIO Rural Development

SCORE CARD The

state fares badly when it comes to medical facilities and safe drinking water. Malnutrition deaths continue to plague rural areas. Maharashtra has among the highest number of farmer suicides in India.

WORK IN PROGRESS Vidarbha continues to get step-motherly treatment from the state Government.

While petty politics may have impacted the NCP's showing in the Lok Sabha elections, the dismal performance over the last five years of key ministries like home, irrigation, excise, rural development and power has the Congress even more worried. All of these portfolios, which are not only "lucrative" but also offer a chance to impact public life, were with the NCP. Key ministries like energy and home directly concern the common man and in both these, the party has severely underperformed. Says Suresh Jain, former NCP MLA who has defected to the Shiv Sena: "The party is not interested in governance but only in swallowing money. The power shortage could have been resolved by giving assistance to power plants but the NCP has always invited trouble by not sanctioning

the mismanagement of key portfolios like home and power. Senior officials in the Home and Excise Department claim that police stations are auctioned as are key postings. A lucrative posting for an excise officer at the taluka level fetches over Rs 40 lakh.

Another matter of concern is the growing ambition and influence of Ajit, whose strong-arm tactics have upset many local leaders. Given that Sharad Pawar does not intervene in the day-to-day running of the state, he is pretty much his uncle's voice. Whether it is the appointment of the party's state president or the transfer of key bureaucrats, Ajit's is the last word in the party, says a Congress minister. In fact, the Congress finds it difficult to make Ajit see reason, and on such occasions they ask Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel

"The Congress has a traditional votebank while the NCP has no vote-base."

VILASRAO DESHMUKH, MINISTER OF HEAVY INDUSTRIES



land acquisition or water supply."

Despite being in a coalition government, the NCP ministers never consulted its alliance partner. The ministries functioned in isolation, without any input from the chief minister. In fact, during Deshmukh's stint, senior police officers would not respond to his calls or queries as they owed allegiance to Sharad Pawar and his nephew Ajit. The Congress even put up a huge fight against the appointment of A.N. Roy as the director-general of Maharashtra Police but the NCP kept sending the file till Deshmukh signed it.

There has always been a tug-of-war related to key positions such as the commissioner and director-general of Maharashtra Police. Any administrative stand would have resulted in a political crisis, so the Congress has had to be silent on

to settle the deadlock.

In the absence of a clear succession plan, the NCP is divided into several factions. Second-rung leaders have now realised that they will never succeed Sharad Pawar, thanks to his ambitions for daughter Supriya Sule. While one faction is keen on merging with the Congress, another camp is open to crossing over to it. The Congress, however, is not opening its doors just yet as it does not want to be seen wooing people away from its alliance partner. The Congress-NCP tie-up may survive the forthcoming elections, but a merger is not far away. With an aggressive Ajit calling the shots in the Maharashtra NCP, Sharad Pawar's heir Sule would be better off in the Congress rather than battling her cousin in the state. It's a prophecy Deshmukh loves to make. ■